artists, calligraphers and poets to his exhibition. When he finished painting a cat in a few bold strokes, one of his friends added a short poem in exquisite calligraphy. Another painter added, with a few quick dabs with brush and ink, a clump of reeds next to the cat. Another painter-friend added a butterfly hovering around the cat. And only then was the painting complete. Such a collective effort is alien to most other cultures.

China had a tradition of meritocracy because of its examination-based civil service, which persisted through the dynastic changes in the country. In India, distribution of positions within the state system was mostly confined to caste-based hierarchies and kinship networks, thus perpetuating economic and social inequalities. Despite independent India introducing a merit-based bureaucracy selected through annual competitive examinations, social inequalities remain stubbornly entrenched in an ostensibly egalitarian democracy.

In China, religion was sometimes harnessed by the state to advance its interests, but most often this was done to prevent religion from threatening political power. In India, the state, in its different incarnations, proved, by and large, to be remarkably accommodative of different religious persuasions, despite periods of violent persecution of adherents of this or that faith. This was also because the State in India intervened less in the lives of ordinary citizens than was the case in China.

What is striking about both countries is their immense diversity. But while China has a certain preference for strong central authority, India’s strength may lie in managing diversity.

Peter Hessler, Oracle Bones: A Journey Through Time in China, HarperCollins, 2006.

A Record of Buddhist Kingdoms: Being an Account by a Chinese Monk Fa-Hein of Travels in India and Ceylon, 399–414 AD, translated by James Legge, Munshiram Manoharlal Publishers, December 1992.

Huen Tsang (Xuan Zang), Si-Yu-Ki: Buddhist Records of the Western World, translated by Samuel Beal, 1884, reprint by Oriental Books Reprint Corporation, 1968.

Sheldon Pollock and Benjamin Elman, eds., What China and India Once Were: The Pasts That May Shape the Global Future, Random House, 2018.